# 6.
# PHYSICAL FICTIONS: INVITATIONS TO MAKE-BELIEVE

As science fiction author Bruce Sterling pointed out in a public conversation with us about design fiction, there are many forms of fictional objects outside art and design, including patents and failed inventions.[1] These are fictional objects but they are accidental fictions. We are more interested in intentional fictional objects, physical fictions that celebrate and enjoy their status with little desire to become "real."

One way of considering the fictional objects of speculative design is as props for nonexistent films. On encountering the object, the viewer imagines his or her own version of the film world the object belongs to. Film prop design, therefore, might seem like good source of inspiration for these



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objects but as Piers D. Britton points out in "Design for Screen SF,"[2] film props have to be legible and support plot development; they have to be readable, which undermines their potential to surprise and challenge. They are instrumental in moving the plot along. As director Alfonso Cuarón puts it when talking about his film *Children of Men* (2006), "Also rule number one in the film is recognisability. We don't want to do *Blade Runner*—actually, we talk about being the anti-*Blade Runner* in the sense of how we were approaching reality. And that was kind of difficult for the Art Department, because I would say, 'I don't want inventiveness, I want reference'. [. . .] And, more important, I would like, as much as possible, references of contemporary iconography that is already ingrained in human consciousness."[3]

This is the main difference between film props and the fictional objects of design speculations. The objects used in design speculations can extend beyond a filmic support function and break away from clichéd visual languages that prop designers are often obliged to use. Yes, it makes reading the objects more difficult but this process of mental interaction is important for encouraging the viewer to actively engage with the design rather than passively consuming it. This separates design speculations from design for cinema. The presence of the prop in the same space as the imaginer also makes the experience more vivid, more alive, and more intense. For example Patricia Piccinini's *The Young Family*[4] (2002) consists of a hyper-realistic life-size model of a transgenic creature with vaguely human characteristics suckling her children. The object is shocking and powerful. It is neither an argument for nor against biotechnology but is simply one possible future lying ahead of us and it is up to the viewers to decide for themselves if they agree or not. Although the object is presented in hyper-realistic detail, the world it belongs to will be different for each person who sees it.

## PROPS AND MAKE-BELIEVE THEORY

A more useful way of thinking about the fictional objects of speculative design is Kendall L. Walton's theory of make-believe: props are objects that "prescribe imaginings" and "generate fictional truths." Being "caught up in a story" means "to participate psychologically in a game in which the story (or play or painting) is a prop."[5] Props used in design speculations are functional and skillfully designed; they facilitate imagining and help us entertain ideas about everyday life that might not be obvious. They help us think about alternative possibilities—they challenge the ideals, values, and beliefs of our society embodied in material culture.



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Patricia Piccinini, *The Young Family*, 2002. Photograph by Graham Baring. Photograph courtesy of the artist and Haunch of Venison.

The speculative prop designer needs to be skilled at triggering an imaginative response in the viewer but the viewer already has to be open to imagining other ways life could be. When we read a book we build the world alluded to in it in our imagination, but the main purpose is to identify with characters and situations beyond our own lives, to put ourselves in the position of others, for entertainment or reflection. It takes imaginative effort but the result is the viewer or reader takes ownership of the idea, and each experience is different. Films also require us to put ourselves in the place of the protagonist but they require less effort because we are immersed in a high-resolution world designed to push our emotional buttons. The props of speculative design are different. They are triggers that can help us construct in our minds a world shaped by different ideals, values, and beliefs to our own, better or worse, that we can entertain and reflect on.



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Whereas a child uses props to imagine a box is a house or a rock is an alien, speculative design props are intended not to mimic reality or allow us to play act but to entertain new ideas, thoughts, and possibilities for an alternative world from the one we and the prop coexist in, what Kendall calls "fictional propositions" in contrast to the "fictional truths" of children's props.[6] The prop belongs to its own fictional world; it expands our imaginative horizons and provides new perspectives. Toys such as dolls and guns stand in for real guns and people and allow the child to participate in a game of make-believe with predefined rules. Heavily branded products work in a similar way to children's toys allowing their owner to act out a role—important executive, wealthy playboy, creative genius. Speculative design props do not stand in for the real thing and do not fit into predefined behavioral schema; they are physical fictions, departure points for sophisticated imaginings never meant to be viewed as "real," or to reflect reality.

For some, the term *prop* means a fake object, something that doesn't work, but in the context of a speculative design, a prop can be a fully working prototype or not. This is not the issue; its purpose is to facilitate imagining. What makes them different from products is that they do not "fit" into today's world, especially the commercial world. This is what makes them "unreal." They are at odds with how things are. It is the emphasis on transporting the imagination that distinguishes them from other object types including products, prototypes, and models.

Speculative design props function as physical synecdoches, parts representing wholes designed to prompt speculation in the viewer about the world these objects belong to. This approach requires viewers to creatively engage with the props and make them their own. There is a skill and craft to positioning a speculative design, "what the reader or viewer does is to project meanings into the work of art, not any meanings but choices from a family of meanings that the work suggests."[7] The Islanders[8] (1998–) by artist Charles Avery does this beautifully. For more than a decade he has worked on one project, an imaginary island, producing work based on the observations a fictitious traveler has brought back. The project consists of drawings, objects, models, found bones, and so on through which the island can be imagined.



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Charles Avery, *Duculi*, 2006. Photograph courtesy of the artist.

## USER AS IMAGINER

Props require a shift in the role of viewers, too; they must become active "imaginers." This is something people do when they visit museums to view historical artifacts, often carrying out a sort of imaginary archeology on the artifacts on display. Prefigurative futures (or pre-enactments?) also use props to transport viewers' imagination[9] but, whereas in this role they are bringing a specific future to the present so that it can be partially experienced in advance, user-tested, or prepared for, we are more interested in using props to transport viewers' imagination into a thought experiment, or what-if, and allow enough room for them to make their own interpretations.



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Viewers need to understand the rules of the game and how a speculative design prop is meant to function in a given situation. This is very difficult because viewers are not used to encountering designed objects with this purpose either in the press or exhibitions. The closest relatives we can think of are historical everyday artifacts in museum collections that prompt us to imagine what life must have been like in those societies. One challenge for design criticism is to clarify and promote new rules and expectations for viewing speculative design objects in noncommercial settings such as museums and galleries as props designed to trigger social imagining and critical reflection on alternative possibilities for our technologically mediated lives.

## SUSPENSION OF DISBELIEF

There is a very important difference between inviting viewers to "make-believe" and asking them to "believe." For props to work, viewers have to suspend their disbelief, willingly. They have to agree to believe in it. This creates the most room for aesthetic experimentation because it frees the design from mimicking reality and referencing the already known.

Asking people to believe can very quickly lead to faking, trickery, and hoaxes. We also avoid parody and pastiche that pretend to be real. We prefer to acknowledge that a prop is a fiction by slightly exaggerating its unreality and signaling that it is an invitation to imagine, speculate, and dream. It takes imagination from the viewer and goodwill but the alternative seems unfair and possibly even unethical. For us, fooling the viewer into believing something is real is cheating. We prefer viewers to willingly suspend their disbelief and to enjoy shifting their imagination into a new, unfamiliar, and playful space.

*Plant Fiction* (2010) by the design collective Troika, does this well. The project consists of five scenarios, each based on a fictitious plant species mixing fact and fiction to address a very specific issue such as pollution, energy, or recycling through its design. Each is accompanied by a short text hinting at its purpose and situating it in a particular location in a near-future London. *Selfeater (Agave autovora),* for example, breaks down its own cellulose to aid ethanol fermentation and is located beneath the elevated motorways near Barrier Point Road. The images are precise, hyper-realistic computer renderings of visually plausible but technically fictional plants on white backgrounds that subtly communicate their status as speculative designs.



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Troika, *Plant Fiction: Selfeater (Agave autovora)*, 2010. Photograph © Troika 2010.

There is another subtle distinction that needs to be managed during the creation of speculative design props: the difference between believable and plausible. It is sometimes said in TV and cinema that "you can ask an audience to believe the impossible, but not the improbable,"[10] or as James Wood writes in *How Fiction Works*, "This is surely why Aristotle writes that a convincing impossibility in mimesis is always preferable to an unconvincing possibility."[11] A speculative design prop does not need to be realistic, just plausible. This is extremely difficult to get right and is at the aesthetic heart of designing props for make-believe. Within a particular context or world, which may be impossible, certain things are still improbable. For example, if we are watching a film in which a group of people are on their way to Mars and are suddenly confronted by an alien in the ship, if their reaction to the alien does



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not match what we would expect, then everything falls apart. Yet, the whole premise, including the existence of aliens, is a fiction that we accept. Once viewers understand the rules they are very strict about allowing themselves to break them. Inconsistency is the issue; there has to be internal consistency within the world the prop belongs to.

## DESIGN VOICE

Designing for unreality has its own aesthetic rules. Somehow these objects, scenes, characters, interactions, and activities must appear "real" but gently signal that they are not. They must be plausible but not necessarily believable. In everyday life products usually need to be subdued; for props, drama becomes important. In everyday life we design for users and the design language needs to be transparent and natural. In fiction we are designing for a viewer or imaginer and the design language needs to be unnatural and even glitchy.

In *How Fiction Works,* James Wood writes,

> the novelist is always working with at least three languages. There is the author's own language, style, perceptual equipment, and so on; there is the character's presumed language, style perceptual equipment, and so on; and there is what we could call the language of the world—the language which fiction inherits before it gets to turn it into novelistic style, the language of daily speech, of newspapers, of offices, of advertising, of the blogosphere and text messaging. In this sense the novelist is a triple-writer, and the contemporary novelist now feels especially the pressure of this tripleness, thanks to the omnivorous presence of the third horse of this troika, the language of the world, which has invaded our subjectivity, our intimacy, the intimacy that James thought should be the proper quarry of the novel, and which he called (in a troika of his own) "the palpable present-intimate."[12]

We believe this is true for design props as well, that props can have multiple voices or languages, or more accurately, perspectives they can be designed from. The most interesting voice, or perspective to design from, for us, and probably most neglected, is the designer's own language. Usually this is missing in design fictions because designers try to make their design prop as "realistic" as possible by using the prop's presumed language, the language of the world as we understand it, for example, mass manufacture,



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corporate, do-it-yourself, and so on, what people expect and understand design to mean and look like in a specific context. In *Toys* (2009) by designer Tommaso Lanza, the fictional products he designed intentionally conform to what we expect technological products bought by a corporate bank to look like (the language of the world). Here the designer imports the design language of a specific world into the fiction. Our own project, *Technological Dreams No.1: Robots* (2007), is expressed through our own design language, the language of the designer and author, which intentionally does not connect with a viewer's expectation of what robots should look like. And in Sputniko's *Menstruation Machine* (2010) the designer embeds herself in the fictional world of the project and uses the presumed language of the main character, the builder of the DIY device. The prop's "voice" is often overlooked but offers interesting possibilities for playing with viewers' expectations to create deeper engagement.

Dunne & Raby, *All the Robots*, 2007, from the project *Technological Dreams No. 1: Robots*, 2007. Photograph by Per Tingleff.



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Tommaso Lanza, *Shredders*, 2009, from the series *Playgrounds/Toys*.
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Tommaso Lanza, *Shoe*, 2009, from the series *Playgrounds/Toys*.
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Sputniko, *Menstruation Machine*, 2010. Photograph by Rai Royal.



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## DESIGN FICTION

Speculative design overlaps with several other emerging design approaches but design fiction is probably the closest, and the terms are often used interchangeably. It is a vaguely defined space where speculative, fictional, and imaginary design all collide and fuse. Although there are obvious similarities, we think there are some important differences. Bruce Sterling defines design fiction as "the deliberate use of diegetic[13] prototypes to suspend disbelief about change,"[14] which could also describe a precursor of design fiction sometimes referred to as "artifacts from the future." As it is popularly understood, design fiction is a narrower genre. It has grown out of the technology industry, and as the "fiction" part of the label references science fiction rather than general fiction, it places a strong emphasis on technological futures. Because of this, design fiction is increasingly being understood as a genre of future vision video (sometimes photos but rarely stand-alone objects) designed specifically for circulation on the Internet rather than in exhibitions. Another variation is Brian David Johnson's idea of sci-fi prototyping, which is a more applied version that focuses specifically on using fiction to quickly explore implications for technology in workshops.[15] Inevitably, design fiction suffers from some of the issues associated with film props mentioned at the beginning of this chapter, namely, a dependence on referencing the already known. We are more interested in using fictional designs to suggest things can be very different indeed, consequently our fictions are glitchy, strange, disruptive, and hint at other places, times, and values.

We do of course still use film and photography but rather than using them to ground the designs in "reality" or designing specifically for video, we prefer to use them to extend the imaginative possibilities of the physical prop, adding more layers and opening up more possibilities. Video and photography are secondary media. The physical prop is the starting point for a chain reaction developed through other media rather than a reality anchor for the video.

Like Margaret Atwood's preference for the term *speculative literature* over *science fiction*, we prefer the term s*peculative design* over *design fiction*. Although, strictly speaking, we produce fictional designs, they have a broader purpose than the design fiction genre allows. Another difference that separates design fictions from the kind of fictional design we are interested in is that they are rarely critical of technological progress and border on celebration rather than questioning.



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